

Refining the internal structure of expressive binominal structures: a view from Italian

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1 Introduction

Several languages display Qualitative Binominal Noun Phrases (QBNPs), i.e. binominal structures where the first noun phrase encodes an evaluation by the speaker of the referent denoted by the second noun phrase, and at the same time conveys the emotional state of the speaker. In what follows, we refer to the first noun phrase as the Expressive Noun (henceforth EN), and to the second noun phrase as Referential Noun (henceforth RN). An example of such a structure is given in (1), which conveys the fact that the speaker is annoyed by a professor, for whatever reason.

- (1) That idiot of a professor has disappeared again!

QBNPs have attracted the attention of several linguists over the last several decades, and different hypotheses concerning their pragmatic, semantic, and syntactic properties have been proposed, both in specific languages and cross-linguistically (Napoli 1989, Aarts 1998, Den Dikken 1998, 2006, Matushansky 2001, Potts 2007, Villalba 2008, Doliana 2015, Cuonzo 2019, Giorgi and Polletto 2021a, Cepollaro et al. 2021, Matushansky 2001, Saab 2022b, 2025). These analyses mainly focus on four aspects of QBNPs:

- (i) the semantic and pragmatic contribution of the EN

- (ii) the syntactic structure of QBNPs, i.e. whether QBNPs are syntactically headed by the EN or the RN, which functional projection hosts the EN, and whether the EN is base-generated in the surface position or moves there
- (iii) the formal characterization of the EN, i.e. whether it has a ‘plain’ NP structure, or shares syntactic properties of scalar items
- (iv) the formal characterization of the preposition appearing between the EN and the RN, i.e. whether it heads a PP, or should rather be considered the lexicalization of a functional head, the nominal counterpart of a verbal copula, or a semantically empty linking element.

A common trait shared by the works engaging in these debates is the observation that expressivity has a clear syntactic dimension, namely that expressivity cannot be conceived of as provided by specific lexical items (and the pragmatic inferences they generate) alone (Corver 2016, Gutzmann 2019, Corver 2021, Tsiakmakis and Espinal 2022, Saab 2025). We adopt such a view, and address some of the issues mentioned in the previous paragraph by focusing on Italian QBNPs. Specifically, we argue that Italian provides evidence for the existence of (at least) three different classes of ENs, which differ from each other in terms of (i) semantic and pragmatic contribution to the proposition, (ii) syntactic distribution, and (iii) concord patterns. While the evidence we discuss comes from Italian, we hope that it may help to better understand QBNPs in general. This includes questions as the internal structure of the QBNP, as well as of the ENs, and the morpho-syntactic identity of the preposition-like element surfacing between EN and RN.

Concretely, we argue that the different ENs we identify occupy different syntactic positions, i.e. they can occur in the specifier of a functional projection hosting evaluative adjectives – ValP (Cinque 2010, 2014, Rizzi and Cinque 2016, Scott 2002, Laenzlinger 2005) – or in the Deg-head hosted in the extended projection of such functional projection. We also argue that the expressive component of these ENs is determined by both their syntactic position and the degree to which they are grammaticalized (Cavirani-Pots 2020). More specifically, their different behavior with respect to concord derives from their morpho-syntactic structure, namely from the hypothesis that ENs can be semi-lexical to different degrees, and from the EN having or not having interpretable ϕ -features that can be either valued or unvalued Pesetsky and Torrego (2007). As for the prepositional element occurring between ENs and RNs, we propose that it is a context-dependent realization

of a morphosyntactic structure that is formally and functionally similar to adjectival concord markers.

The QBNPs we discuss feature ENs such as *cazzo* ‘dick’, *merda* ‘shit’, and *stronzo* ‘turd’. These ENs represent the three different classes of ENs we mentioned above. Thus, when discussing *cazzo*, *merda*, and *stronzo*, we henceforth refer to *cazzo*-type ENs as C-ENs, *merda*-type ENs as M-ENs, and *stronzo*-type ENs as S-ENs. Each of these three classes contains several other items, whose use as EN depends on diatopic, diphasic and diastratic factors. In Table 1 we list some representatives of each class (see Masià 2018 for a comparable typology of ENs in Spanish).

C-EN		M-EN		S-EN	
cazzo	‘dick’	merda	‘shit’	stronzo	‘turd’
cavolo	‘cabbage’	schifezza	‘filth’	idiota	‘idiot’
minchia	‘dick’	nullità	‘nonentity’	scemo	‘fool’
belin	‘dick’	meraviglia	‘marvel’	furbone	‘sly person’
accidenti	‘curses’	sventola	‘knock-out’	esperto	‘expert’

Table 1: Three classes of expressive nouns

In what follows, we discuss the properties of items belonging to these classes. More specifically, we discuss the semantic/pragmatic, syntactic, and morphological properties of Italian QBNPs featuring these three classes of EN in Sect. 2. In Sect. 3, we present our theoretical analysis of these QBNPs. Sect. 4 concludes and offers suggestions for future research.

2 Data

The QBNPs we investigate are structures such as those in (2), which all convey the fact that a (situation involving a) specific professor triggers an emotionally loaded reaction by the speaker.

- (2) a. un cazzo di professore
 a dick of professor
 ‘a fucking professor’
 b. una merda di professore
 a shit of professor
 ‘a shithead of a professor’

- c. uno stronzo di professore
a turd of professor
'an asshole of a professor'

At first blush, the structures in (2) look identical. However, they show semantic, pragmatic, and morphosyntactic differences. We address the semantic and pragmatic differences in Sect. 2.1, where we discuss (i) valence (Sect. 2.1.1), (ii) (non-)occurrence with an adjective modifying the RN (Sect. 2.1.2), (iii) animacy (Sect. 2.1.3), (iv) NPI behavior and behavior as expletive with *wh*-items (Sect. 2.1.4), and (v) occurrence in attributive vs. comparative QBNPs (Sect. 2.1.5). In Sect. 2.2, we show that ENs also differ morphosyntactically, in terms of (i) (non-)occurrence in predicative position (Sect. 2.2.1), (ii) stacking patterns (Sect. 2.2.2, and (iii) concord patterns (Sect. 2.2.3). We conclude this data section with a note on pure and mixed expressives (Sect. 2.3).

2.1 Semantics/pragmatics

2.1.1 Valence

A first distinction that sets apart C-ENs from M-ENs S-ENs concerns their valence.

- (3) Valence
M-ENs and S-ENs have an intrinsic (positive or negative) valence, whereas the valence of C-ENs is underspecified.

In the case where the valence of the emotion is underspecified, it can be provided by either the RN, or the extralinguistic context. We show this for a C-EN in (4a), which expresses admiration on the part of the speaker. C-ENs contrast with M-ENs (4b) and S-ENs (4c), which cannot have this reading.

- (4) a. Che cazzo di genio, quel Cantachiaro!
What dick of genius that Cantachiaro!
'What a hell of a genius, that Cantachiaro!'
- b. #Che merda di genio, quel Cantachiaro!
What shit of genius that Cantachiaro!
- c. #Che stronzo di genio, quel Cantachiaro!
What turd of genius that Cantachiaro!

In these examples, the M-ENs and S-ENs are infelicitous, as they clash with the positive valence of the RN *genio* ‘genius’.

In the following case, positive valence is not a property of the RN – *professore* ‘professor’ has a neutral valence – but of the extralinguistic context.

- (5) Context: professor Cantachiaro is reported to always accommodate his students’ needs, while also being a charming teacher and a brilliant researcher. Judith extols his virtues in a conversation with a fellow student, Varun, and then concludes:
- a. Judith: Cantachiaro sì che è un cazzo di professore!
Cantachiaro yes that is a dick of professor!
‘Cantachiaro is one hell of a professor!’
 - a’. Varun: Sì, è davvero fantastico!
yes is really fantastic!
‘Yes, he is really fantastic!’
 - b. Judith: #Cantachiaro sì che è una merda di professore!
Cantachiaro yes that is a shit of professor!
‘Cantachiaro is a shithead of a professor!’
 - b’. Varun: Ma sei diventata matta?!
but are.2SG.PRS become crazy
‘Have you gone mad?!’
 - c. Judith: #Cantachiaro sì che è uno stronzo di professore!
Cantachiaro yes that is a turd of professor!
‘Cantachiaro is an asshole of a professor!’
 - c’. Varun: Ma sei diventata matta?!
but are.2SG.PRS become crazy
‘Have you gone mad?!’

In (5a), the C-EN matches the extremely positive attitude of Judith towards the professor, which is backed up by the reply by Varun. In contrast, (5b) and (5c) are infelicitous because there is a mismatch between the positive valence of the context and the negative valence in the descriptive content of the M-EN and S-EN, which licenses Varun’s skeptical reply.¹

¹The judgments of the Italian QBNPs discussed in this paper were made by one of the authors, who is an Italian native speaker, and have been checked with other Italian native speakers. Most of these QBNPs can also be easily found online. The relevance of the context for the felicitous use of M-ENs and S-ENs in QBNPs has been shown experimentally by Cepollaro et al. (2021).

2.1.2 Occurrence with an adjective modifying the RN

Another property setting apart C-ENs from the M-ENs and S-ENs is their compatibility with adjectives modifying the RN.

- (6) Occurrence with adjectives modifying the RN
C-ENs are compatible with adjectives modifying the RN, while M-ENs and S-ENs are not.

In the case of C-ENs, if the adjective expresses a property that has an intrinsic valence, while the C-EN intensifies such positive or negative property:

- (7) a. Quel Cantachiaro ha una cazzo di bella macchina!
That Cantachiaro has a dick of beautiful car
'That Cantachiaro has a hell of a beautiful car!'
b. Quel Cantachiaro ha una cazzo di brutta macchina!
That Cantachiaro has a dick of ugly car
'That Cantachiaro has a fucking ugly car!'

In these examples, the C-EN “boost[s] the degree to which a property [i.e. *bella* or *brutta*] holds” (Beltrama and Trotzke 2019). Thus, semantically (and syntactically; see below), C-ENs can be understood as intensifiers, which “signal high degree of emotional involvement on the part of the speaker, with the specific type, polarity, and intensity of the emotion depending on the specific lexical item and the contextual setting” (Beltrama and Trotzke 2019: 4; see also Kaplan 1999, Potts 2007).² As argued by Beltrama and Trotzke (2019: 3), intensifiers like our C-EN boost “the degree to which a property holds [and] convey emphasis by inducing [an] ordering-based partition of the denotation”. See also Beltrama (2018), Gutzmann and Turgay (2015), and Floricic and Milioni (2021: 483), who explicitly claim that a C-EN such as *cazzo* “behaves as an intensifier or a focus particle that produces a high

²Basso and de Souza (2025) show that in Brazilian Portuguese *puta* can also be used as an intensifier with a positive or negative valence, depending on the context:

- (i) a. Foi uma puta de uma festa!
'It was a hell of a party!'
b. Que puta de barulho!
'What a dreadfully loud noise!'

Similarly, En. *fucking* can also be used as an intensifier, as in *really fucking brilliant* (Geurts 2007, Gutzmann 2011). We are grateful to a reviewer for pointing this out to us.

degree reading [which] operates at a qualitative/subjective level, reinforcing the affectedness of the individual involved in the state of affair referred to”.

The intensifier nature of C-ENs is even clearer in an example such as the one in (8), where the two sentences uttered by speaker B in response to a claim by speaker A are a minimal pair, distinguished only by the presence of the C-EN in the second sentence.

- (8) A Quella è una bella macchina!
 That is a beautiful car
 ‘That one is a beautiful car!’
 B No, quella non è una bella macchina, è una cazzo di
 No, that not is a beautiful car, is a dick of
 bella macchina!
 beautiful car
 ‘No, that’s not a beautiful car, it’s a fucking beautiful car!’

In contrast, M-ENs and S-ENs do not tolerate any adjective modifying the RN, regardless of its valence, and they do not function as intensifiers. This is shown in (9b) for M-ENs and in (10b) for S-ENs.

- (9) a. *Quel Cantachiaro ha una merda di bella macchina!
 That Cantachiaro has a shit of beautiful car
 b. *Quel Cantachiaro ha una merda di brutta macchina!
 That Cantachiaro has a shit of ugly car
 (10) a. *Quel Cantachiaro ha una stronza di fantastica sorella!
 That Cantachiaro has a turd of fantastic sister
 b. *Quel Cantachiaro ha una stronza di pessima sorella!
 That Cantachiaro has a turd of awful sister

The a-examples are not surprising, since we know independently that M-ENs and S-ENs are incompatible with positive valence. In the b-examples, on the other hand, the negative valence of the M-EC *merda* and the S-EN *stronzo* aligns with the negative valence of *brutta*. Thus, there seems to be no semantic or pragmatic reason why these ENs could not be combined with the adjective. This suggests that the problem is with M-ENs and S-ENs modifying—or embedding—an adjective, rather than a bare noun. This, in turn, suggests that M-ENs and S-ENs do not show the intensifier-like nature of C-ENs.

As shown in (7a), C-ENs intensify expressions that are gradable, e.g. adjectives such as *beautiful*, *old*, etc., but also, as we saw in (5), expressions that are not intrinsically gradable, like the noun *professore*. This is reminiscent of English expressive elements such as *totally* and *so*, which, in (11a) and (11b), co-occur with phrases that are in principle non-gradable phrases, such as *click-on-a-link* and *next-in-line*.³

- (11) a. You should totally click on that link! (Beltrama 2016)
b. Chris is so next in line! (Potts 2005)

Despite their non-gradability, *totally* and *so* coerce a gradable reading of *click-on-a-link* and *next-in-line*, which “is rooted in the speaker’s attitude, rather than in the denotation of the predicate—i.e., in how excited, certain, or surprised the speaker is about what they are saying” Beltrama and Trotzke (2019: 3). This is what we observe in (5) too, where the C-EN *cazzo* seems to coerce the RN *professore* into a gradable reading, i.e. to “boost the degree to which a property [of the RN] holds”. One way to conceive of this is to argue that when not modifying an overt adjective (7a), the C-EN *cazzo* modifies an empty adjective whose content either encodes the prototypical properties of the RN (e.g. in cases in which the RN has some intrinsic valence, as in (4a)), or is contextually determined, as in (5). We return to this point in Sect. 3.2.1.

2.1.3 Animacy

S-ENs have a meaning component of animacy, which C- and M-ENs lack.

- (12) Animacy
C-ENs and M-ENs can be used with any sort of RN; S-ENs are only compatible with [+animate] RNs.

The first half of this generalization is illustrated in (13a) and (13b)), the second half in (13c).

- (13) a. Quel cazzo di professore / motorino
that dick of professor / scooter

³Another English structure coercing a gradable reading is *much of a*, as in *he’s not much of a cook*. Interestingly, as our Italian QBNPs, such structures display a ‘spurious’ *of*.

- ‘that fucking professor / scooter’
- b. Quella merda di professore / motorino
that shit of professor / scooter
‘that shithead of a professor/that fucking scooter’
- c. Quello stronzo di professore / *motorino
that turd of professor / scooter
‘that asshole of a professor/scooter’

2.1.4 NPI and expletive-like behavior

NPI and expletive-like behavior also set apart the C-ENs from the M-ENs and S-ENs.

- (14) a. C-ENs can be used as NPIs, M-ENs and S-ENs cannot.
- b. C-ENs can be used as expletives with *wh*-items, M-ENs and S-ENs cannot.

The NPI use is illustrated in (15a), and the expletive use in (15b) (examples from Giorgi and Poletto 2021b; see also Doliana 2016).

- (15) a. Non ha capito un cazzo / *una merda / *uno
not have.3SG.PRS understood a dick / a shit / a
stronzo (di niente)!
turd (of nothing)
‘He hasn’t understood shit!’
- b. Che cazzo / *merda / *stronzo fai?
what dick / shit / turd do.2SG.PRS?
‘What the fuck are you doing?’

In this NPI use, C-ENs can be found that occur in predicative position (which is otherwise impossible; see Sect. 2.2.1 below). This is shown in (16).

- (16) Io sono io, e voi non siete un cazzo.
I am I, and you not be.2PL.PRS a dick
‘I am me, and you are fucking nothing.’ (Belli 1960)

Crucially, in this example, there is negation at the sentential level, and the C-EN occurring in predicative position functions as an NPI. We take this NPI use of C-ENs to be a quite different phenomenon from its use in QBNPs, and therefore will set it aside in the remainder of the paper. We want to highlight

though that also in this context, C-ENs have an intensifier semantics, as shown by the alternative English translation of (16): ‘I am me, and you’re *really* nothing’.

2.1.5 Occurrence in attributive vs. comparative QBNPs

C-ENs, M-ENs, and S-ENs also differ from each other with respect to whether they can receive attributive and comparative readings (Den Dikken 2006).

- (17) M-ENs and S-ENs are ambiguous between an attributive and a comparative reading; C-ENs do not license a comparative reading.

In the attributive reading, a RN—e.g. *a professor*—is intended to have the property expressed by the EN—e.g. being *an idiot*—‘in his capacity as a professor’, whereas in the comparative reading, the RN is intended to have the property expressed by the EN ‘in his capacity as a human being’.⁴ Napoli (1989) observes that in Italian QBNPs with an attributive reading, RNs do not bear a determiner, while in QBNPs with a comparative reading, they do. As shown in (18), in the attributive reading *di* is followed by a bare noun. If *di* is followed by a definite or indefinite article, the comparative reading is triggered (19).

- (18) ATTRIBUTIVE
- a. Quella merda di professore è scomparso di nuovo!
that shit of professor is disappeared of new
‘That shithead of a professor has disappeared again!’
 - b. Quello stronzo di professore è scomparso di nuovo!
that turd of professor is disappeared of new
‘That asshole of a professor has disappeared again!’

- (19) COMPARATIVE
- a. Quella merda del/di un professore è scomparso di nuovo!
that shit of.the/of a professor is disappeared of new

⁴Den Dikken (2006) has argued that the difference depends on the syntactic derivation of the relevant QBNP. In his view, the attributive reading arises when the predicate—*idiot*—is base-generated in a position that is higher than the one occupied by its subject—*professor*, whereas the comparative reading arises when the predicate is raised by a predicate inversion operation (Den Dikken 2006: 162). While we do not discuss comparative QBNPs, we agree with Den Dikken (2006) that attributive and comparative QBNPs have different syntactic structures, depending on the presence or absence of predicate inversion.

- ‘That shithead of a professor has disappeared again!’
- b. Quello stronzo del/di un professore è scomparso di nuovo!
 that turd of.the/of a professor is disappeared of new
 ‘That asshole of a professor has disappeared again!’

These two readings are possible with both M-ENs and S-ENs. In contrast, C-ENs can only be followed by a bare noun (20), indicating that they have no comparative reading.⁵

- (20) a. ATTRIBUTIVE
 Quel cazzo di professore è scomparso di nuovo!
 that idiot of.the/of a professor is disappeared of new
 ‘That fucking professor has disappeared again!’
- b. COMPARATIVE
 *Quel cazzo del/di un professore è scomparso di nuovo!
 that idiot of.the/of a professor is disappeared of new
 Int. ‘That fucking professor has disappeared again!’

In the remainder of the paper, we focus on the attributive QBNPs, i.e. the environment where the three classes of ENs can occur, leaving a full discussion and analysis of comparative QBNPs with M-ENs and S-ENs for future research.

2.1.6 Summary

In Table 2, we give a summary of all the semantic and pragmatic properties of C-ENs, M-ENs and S-ENs discussed in this section.

In the overwhelming majority of the pragmatic and semantic properties, C-ENs are set apart from M-ENs and S-ENs. The only exception to such generalization is that S-ENs require an animate RN, whereas neither C-ENs nor M-ENs do. In the next section, we show that differences in the morphosyntactic behavior provide further support for the proposed three-way distinction.

⁵By ‘bare’ we mean the absence of an article. C-ENs can, in fact, be followed by a bare RN modified by an evaluative adjective, as in *quel cazzo di bel professore*, as discussed above in Sect. 2.1.2.

EN	valence	adj.	animacy	NPI	<i>wh</i> -expl	attrib.	comparat.
C	✗	✓	✗	✓	✓	✓	✗
M	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✓	✓
S	✓	✗	✓	✗	✗	✓	✓

Table 2: Semantic/pragmatic properties of C-ENs, M-ENs, and S-ENs

2.2 Morphosyntax

2.2.1 Occurence in predicative position

Not all the ENs behave alike when it comes to their ability to occur as predicates in copular sentences.

- (21) M-ENs and S-ENs can occur in predicative position; C-ENs cannot occur in predicative position.

The distributional difference is illustrated in (22).⁶

- (22) a. *Cantachiaro è un cazzo!
 Cantachiaro is a dick
 Int. ‘Cantachiaro is a dick.’
 b. Cantachiaro è una merda!
 Cantachiaro is a shit
 ‘Cantachiaro is a shithead.’
 c. Cantachiaro è uno stronzo!
 Cantachiaro is a turd
 ‘McCarrigle is an asshole.’

The ungrammaticality of (22a) militates against the hypothesis of Den Dikken (2006: 164-165), which holds that all ENs ascribe “a property to the noun phrase” they combine with, and since “property ascription, in general, is structurally represented in the form of a predication structure, with the ascriber of the property being the predicate and the ascribe the subject”, it is reasonable to endorse “a syntactic structure underlying all QBNPs according

⁶Despite it being quite absurd in a normal conversation, (22a) is acceptable under the literal reading of *cazzo* ‘dick’, . This is because besides the EN *cazzo*, the Italian lexicon also contains a fully lexical *cazz-* root as well, which refers to actual male genitals.

to which there is a predication relationship between the two noun phrases”. We argue that the hypothesis that ENs predicate something over the RN, in fact, is never true for C-ENs (see also Doetjes and Rooryck 2003). We assume that the impossibility of C-ENs to occur in predicative position is due to their intensifier component (cf. **that book is very/more*, It. **quel libro è molto/più*). This predicts that ENs which are not intensifiers—i.e. M-ENs and S-ENs—can occur predicatively, as they do.

C-ENs thus clearly behave differently from M-ENs and S-ENs with respect to the possibility of occurring in predicative position. M-ENs and S-ENs differ from each other too, though. Consider the following examples.

- (23) a. Cantachiaro è *(una) merda!
 Cantachiaro is a shit
 ‘Cantachiaro is a shithead.’
 b. Cantachiaro è (uno) stronzo!
 Cantachiaro is a turd
 ‘Cantachiaro is an asshole.’

M-ENs cannot occur in predicative position without an article (23a), while S-ENs can occur both with and without article (23b). Note that this is not because S-ENs can be used as adjectives, as shown by the fact that, in the prenominal position, *quello stupido professore* ‘that stupid professor’, contrasts with **quello stronzo professore*, which, in turn, contrasts with *quello stronzo di professore* ‘that asshole of a professor’. Hence, ENs are nouns, which behave like other nouns that can occur without an article in predicative position, e.g. nouns referring to a function or profession (e.g. *Maria è professore* ‘Maria is a professor’), or the so-called *noms de qualité* (Milner 1978, Ruwet 1982, Rainer 2015). Such nouns can be without an article in predicative position, but need one when modified by an adjective (*Maria è un buon professore* ‘Maria is a good professor’).

To sum up, the behavior of ENs in predicative position confirms our earlier claim that there are three classes of EN. This three-fold typology aligns with the one we identified on semantic and pragmatic grounds in the previous section. As we show in Sect. 2.2.3, the ENs display a three-fold behavior with respect to concord patterns too.

2.2.2 Stacking patterns

Another distributional restriction supporting our EN typology concerns the ordering patterns these ENs show when stacked. Stacking ENs is a means to reinforce the speaker’s emotional attitude. Although a full discussion of the possible and impossible patterns is beyond the scope of the present discussion (see Cavirani and Vanden Wyngaerd 2024), there is one fact that we do want to mention.

- (24) Stacking
In pre-RN position, C-ENs precede M-ENs and S-ENs.

We illustrate this for C-ENs and M-ENs in (25).

- (25) a. Quella cazzo di merda di professore!
that dick of shit of professor!
‘that fucking shithead of a professor!’
b. *Quella merda di cazzo di professore!
that shit of dick of professor!

The inverse order is possible in case the C-EN is preceded by *del* rather than *di*.

- (26) Quella merda del cazzo di professore!
that shit of.the dick of professor!
‘That shit of a dick of a professor!’

This *del* is typical of postnominal position of the EN (e.g. *quel professore del cazzo*), which we do not consider here.

2.2.3 EN concord patterns

A third morphosyntactic difference between C-ENs, M-ENs and S-ENs concerns which concord patterns they exhibit in relation to the ϕ -features of the RN and the larger QBNP structure (in particular, the highest D head).

Prior to the discussion of the concord patterns, we want to point out the range of endings that are possible with each EN class. These markers restrict the type of concord patterns we find in the QBNP. As shown, these markers show a three-way contrast.⁷

⁷The table in (27) shows the endings for the three nouns which we have been using

(27)

	C-EN		M-EN		S-EN	
	M	F	M	F	M	F
SG	-o			-a	-o	-a
PL				-e	-i	-e

C-ENs are rigid, showing no alternation in their ending. M-ENs show a number distinction, but no gender distinction, whereas only the S-ENs have the full range of endings, i.e. both gender and number.⁸

Turning to the concord data, we use a set of structures featuring elements that show full concord as a baseline example of concord patterns in Italian noun phrases. In a typical noun phrase, all relevant functional/modifying elements (such as D, POSS, NUM, and ADJ) agree with the RN both in GENDER and NUMBER:

- (28)
- a. Il nostr-o prim-o bel compagn-o
the.M.SG our-M.SG first-M.SG beautiful.M.SG comrade-M.SG
'our first beautiful comrade'
 - b. L-a nostr-a prim-a bell-a compagn-a
the-F.SG our-F.SG first-F.SG beautiful-F.SG comrade-F.SG
'our first beautiful comrade'
 - c. I nostr-i prim-i be-i compagn-i
the.M.PL our-M.PL first-M.PL beautiful-M.PL comrade-M.PL
'our first beautiful comrades'
 - d. L-e nostr-e prim-e bell-e compagn-e
the-F.PL our-F.PL first-F.PL beautiful-F.PL comrade-F.PL
'our first beautiful comrades'

As shown in (29), S-ENs show full concord with the RN. As expected, the demonstrative displays full concord too.

- (29)
- a. Quell-o stronz-o di compagn-o
that-M.SG turd-M.SG of comrade-M.SG

as the representatives of their class, namely *cazzo*, *merda*, and *stronzo*, respectively. As shown in Table 1 above, the class of the C-ENs includes a feminine one (*minchia* 'dick') as well as a plural one (*accidenti* 'curses'). These are rigid like *cazzo*, i.e. they do not allow any variation in their endings.

⁸As argued at the end of section 2.2.1, despite having adjective-like endings, S-ENs are nouns.

- ‘that asshole of a comrade’
- b. Quell-a stronz-a di compagn-a
that-F.SG turd-F.SG of comrade-F.SG
‘that asshole of a comrade’
- c. Quegl-i stronz-i di compagn-i
that-M.PL turd-M.PL of comrade-M.PL
‘those assholes of comrades’
- d. Quell-e stronz-e di compagn-e
that-F.PL turd-F.PL of professor-F.PL
‘those assholes of comrades’

M-ENs behave differently from S-ENs in two respects, as shown in (30). First, M-ENs concord with the RN only in NUMBER, and retain their (intrinsic) GENDER. Thus, *merda* is FEMININE even when it modifies a MASCULINE RN ((30a) and (30c)), and is pluralized—*merde*—when the the RN is PLURAL ((30c) and (30d)). The second difference between S-ENs and M-ENs is that the M-ENs determine the GENDER of higher functional elements, e.g. of the D element *quell-* (while their number is determined by the RN).

- (30)
- a. Quell-a merd-a di compagn-o
that-F.SG shit-F.SG of comrade-M.SG
‘that shithead of a comrade’
 - b. Quell-a merd-a di compagn-a
that-F.SG shit-F.SG of comrade-F.SG
‘that shithead of a comrade’
 - c. Quell-e merd-e di compagn-i
that-F.PL shit-F.PL of comrade-M.PL
‘those shitheads of comrades’
 - d. Quell-e merd-e di compagn-e
that-F.PL shit-F.PL of comrade-F.PL
‘those shitheads of comrades’

Thus, despite the fact that the morphosyntactic structure of S-ENs and M-ENs appears to be identical, the M-ENs look ‘more nouny’ (Ross (1972) et seq.) than the S-ENs, for they keep their GENDER, and determine the one of higher functional elements.⁹

Still different are C-ENs. As shown in (31), their GENDER never agrees

⁹See also Klockmann (2017) et seq. for a formal analysis of semi-lexical nouns and adjectives in English and Polish, in which similar partial concord patterns arise.

with that of RN, nor does their NUMBER. In fact, their GENDER and NUMBER exponence never changes. Furthermore, their GENDER and NUMBER features are never seen by the higher probing functional elements, as shown by the fact that the demonstrative always fully agrees with the RN (31).

- (31)
- a. Quel cazzo di compagn-o
that-M.SG dick.M.SG of comrade-M.SG
'that fucking comrade'
 - b. Quell-a cazzo di compagn-a
that-F.SG dick.M.SG of comrade-F.SG
'that fucking comrade'
 - c. Que-i cazzo di compagn-i
that-M.PL dick.M.SG of comrade-M.PL
'those fucking comrades'
 - d. Quell-e cazzo di compagn-e
that-F.PL dick.M.SG of comrade-F.PL
'those fucking comrades'

Despite the fact that C-ENs seem to have the morphosyntactic structure of a noun, in fact, they look even less 'nouny' than M-ENs, for they are ignored by higher functional elements that need their features valued. We come back to this observation in Sect. 3.2.

2.3 On pure and mixed expressives

In the literature on expressivity, a distinction is often made between pure and mixed expressives (Potts 2005, 2007, McCreedy 2010, Gutzmann 2015, 2019, Floricic and Milioni 2021, Cepollaro et al. 2021, Saab 2022a, Domaneschi et al. 2025). Pure expressives do not convey anything else than the speaker's emotional attitude, like English *damn* in an example like *That damn Cantachiaro arrived late*. But there is no truth-conditional content to *damn*, as witnessed by the fact that *damn* cannot occur as a predicate (**Cantachiaro is damn*). On the basis of this diagnostic test, the C-ENs that we discussed above would be pure expressives, since they cannot occur as predicates, whereas the M-ENs and C-ENs would be mixed expressives, which can also contribute to the at-issue, truth-conditional dimension. It is important to note, though, that most expressive nouns can be used both predicatively and in the binominal construction. Using slightly different terminology, Saab (2022b,c) makes a distinction between epithets and slurs. For him, all cases

of binominals of the type *EN of a RN* are epithets (i.e. pure expressives), regardless of the nature of the EN. The epithet status shows speaker projection, i.e. the negative attitude is attributed to the speaker, even under embedding, as in *Ana cree que el puto de Andrés llegó tarde* ‘Ana believes that the faggot Andrés arrived late’, where the homophobic attitude is attributed to the speaker. Similarly, under negation the speaker projection survives, as in *Ese no es el puto de Andrés* ‘This is not the faggot Andrés’ (examples from Saab 2022b: 366). This is different with slurs, which can involve the same ENs, but used predicatively (e.g. *Andrés es puto* ‘Andrés is a faggot’), or as the head of a nominal constituent (e.g. *el puta del piso de abajo* ‘the faggot of the floor below’). There we see that speaker projection can be absent under embedding (e.g. *Ana cree que Andrés es puto* ‘Ana believes Andrés is a faggot’), and negation takes scope over the slur (*Andrés no es puto* ‘Andrés is not a faggot’).¹⁰

It is important to note that the empirical distinctions we have been discussing in the previous sections all concern the epithet use of the ENs under discussion. These would all be pure expressives under Saab’s analysis. The Italian data we reviewed above suggest that inside this category, there is still a need to make finer distinctions. At this point, we leave it as an open question whether these distinctions can be accommodated under the view that all expressive binominal constructions involve pure expressives, which do not contribute any truth-conditional content. For example, the fact that S-ENs are restricted to animate referents (see (13) above) may suggest the presence of truth-conditional content inside this class of ENs. This is confirmed by the fact that the gender of S-ENs is interpreted. Sudo and Spathas (2020), Janků and Starke (2019) point out that in animate nouns, gender is interpreted, while in inanimates, it is not. S-ENs being animate, their gender is interpreted accordingly, e.g. *È stronzo* can only mean ‘He is a shit’. In contrast, in M-ENs, gender is not interpreted, witness the fact that *È una merda* is gender-neutral, i.e. it can mean ‘He/She is a shit’. While C-ENs have many of the features of pure expressives like *damn*, our analysis of C-ENs as intensifiers (to be presented in the following section) is incompatible with the claim that they are pure expressives.

¹⁰Saab’s view is not unchallenged, as Cepollaro et al. (2021) have argued, on the basis of experimental work, that epithets may not in all contexts or circumstances involve speaker projection.

3 Analysis

In this section, we present a formal analysis of Italian QBNPs, in which we account for the pragmatic, semantic, and morphosyntactic differences discussed in Sect. 2. In Sect. 3.1, we discuss two prerequisites for our analysis, namely (i) Cavarani-Pots’s (2020) account of semi-lexical and functional items and (ii) Manzini’s (2021) work on linking elements. In Sect. 3.2, we present our proposal for the internal make-up of the three types of ENs. In Sect. 3.3, we propose which structural positions the ENs occupy, making a distinction between (i) C-ENs, which occupy a Degree position in the extended projection of an adjectival head, and (ii) M- and S-ENs, which are merged directly in a Spec,VAL position, where VAL is a head introducing evaluative adjectives (Cinque 2014, Rizzi and Cinque 2016). Equipped with (i) the prerequisites, (ii) the make up of the three EN types, and (iii) the two structural merge positions for C-ENs *vs* M-ENs and S-ENs, in Sect. 3.4, we make explicit how our proposal can account for the concord patterns presented in the previous section by means of three syntactic derivations. In that final section, we show that our analysis also accounts for the observed stacking patterns.

3.1 Prerequisites

In this section, we discuss two theoretical prerequisites which need to be spelled out before we can move on to our formal analysis, namely (i) a theory of semi-lexicality proposed by Cavarani-Pots (2020), and (ii) the hypothesis that *di* is an instantiation of concord.

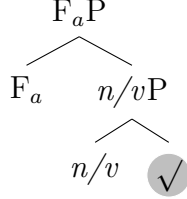
3.1.1 Semi-lexical *vs* functional elements

Cavarani-Pots (2020) presents a formal analysis of grammaticalization, i.e. of the change from lexical to functional. Following decompositional frameworks such as Distributed Morphology (Halle and Marantz 1993) and the Exo-Skeletal framework (Borer 2005, 2013), she assumes that in the lexicon there are only functional features and roots, corresponding to functional and lexical items, respectively. To account for elements whose morphosyntactic and semantic properties are not fully functional nor fully lexical—labeled as ‘semi-lexical’ by among others Corver and van Riemsdijk (2001)—she proposes that these elements are roots that are used in a low position in the extended projection of another root, which is the lexical item at the bottom

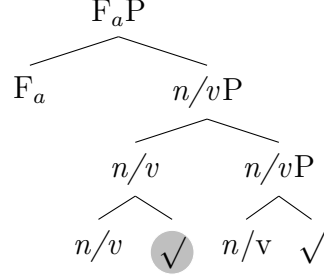
of that projection. Furthermore, she proposes that the transition from lexical to functional takes place in three steps, with two intermediate semi-lexical stages (Cavirani-Pots 2020, Cavirani-Pots et al. 2026).

Let us illustrate her account by means of the structures given in (32)–(35) below. Stage 0 (32) illustrates the syntactic environment and structure of a fully lexical element: a root, sitting at the bottom of its own functional sequence, which gets categorized by v/n . In stage I (33), the semi-lexically used root is still categorized by a categorizing head, and as such still behaves as a noun or verb itself, albeit not one at the bottom of the projection. In stage II (34), the root gets merged in a separate workspace with a functional head instead of a categorizer. This functional head blocks the projection of e.g. NUM- and GEN- features in the case of semi-lexical nouns, or certain selectional requirements in the case of semi-lexical verbs. The presence of the root ensures that the lexical semantics of the element is still partly retained. If a semi-lexical element grammaticalized even further, it would reach the final stage III (35), in which it has lost its root, retaining only the functional feature.

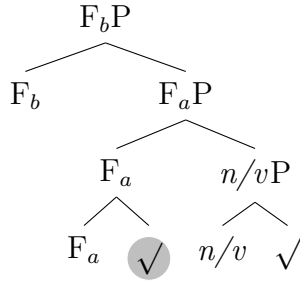
(32) **Stage 0**



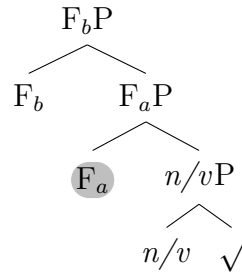
(34) **Stage I**



(33) **Stage II**



(35) **Stage III**



In our analysis, we make use of Cavirani-Pots's (2020) proposal by assuming

that C-ENs are semi-lexical stage II elements, whereas M-ENs and S-ENs are semi-lexical Stage I elements. We elaborate on this further in Sect. 3.2.

3.1.2 *Di* as adjectival concord

We shall now address the role and nature of the element *di* occurring between ENs and RNs. Before developing our own proposal, we review a number of proposals that have been made in the previous literature.

McCawley (1987) claims that preposition and article “are two semantically empty elements [that serve to eliminate] the $[\bar{N} \ N \ \bar{N}]$ combination” (McCawley 1987: 460; see also Richards 2010). Aarts (1998) conceives of QBNPs as structures in which the RN is modified by an EN-*of-a* complex modifier, whose *of-a* part is claimed to be a “syncategorematic formation in adjunct position [that] functions as a pragmatic marker, which signals that phrases that contain it should receive an evaluative reading”. Interestingly, he also notes that, in QBNPs, the emptiness of the preposition explains why it fails to assign case, as shown by German examples such as *ein alter Schelm von Lohnbedienter* (‘an old villain of a waged servant’; Aarts 1998: 151), where the RN has nominative case, rather than the expected dative case following the preposition *von*. Note also that, in Dutch QBNPs, the article preceding the RN does not agree with the NUMBER of the RN, for it has to be SG even if the RN is PL, as in *die idioten van een doktoren* lit. ‘those idiots of a doctors’ (Den Dikken 2006: 170). Despite this NUMBER mismatch, the article is claimed to be selected by *of*, and to take the RN as a complement, the mismatch being due to the indefinite article being of a special, “spurious” kind (Den Dikken 1998, 2006).

Kayne (1994) proposes a predicate inversion analysis of QBNPs, where the English counterpart of Italian *di—of*—is a ‘prepositional determiner [...] comparable to a prepositional complementizer’, which takes the RN as a complement. In a different implementation of the inversion analysis, Den Dikken (2006) argues that the preposition is a *relator*, namely “a semantically empty copula, present for purely structural reasons” (Den Dikken 2006: 166), which corresponds to *as/like* occurring in so-called small clauses. In comparative QBNPs the predicate of the small clause moves higher across the subject, while the relator internally merges with a LINKER head, which “serves multiple purposes: it provides a landing site for the raised predicate, it procures a host for the raised relator and it is an extended phase” (Den Dikken 2006: 161). Crucially, the semantic content of the RELATOR and the LINKER heads

is not entirely made explicit in Den Dikken’s account, and is only defined in functionalist terms (i.e. with respect to the derivational machinery). So, in Den Dikken’s analysis, the preposition is argued not to contribute anything to the semantics of QNBPs, like in Kayne’s.

We now move on to our own proposal for *di*-insertion. In the attributive structures we analyze in this paper, there is no article surfacing between the preposition and the RN, so we do not take a position with respect to this article. Still, we would like to build on the intuition of McCawley (1987), Aarts (1998), Richards (2010) and entertain the hypothesis that the preposition does not head a PP that takes RN as a complement, but rather ‘belongs’ to the preceding EN. Concretely, we propose that *di* spells out the agreement nodes sprouted in the morphological component that are typically found in modifiers (compare also Bobaljik 2006, Marantz 1991, Choi and Harley 2019).¹¹ In other words, we argue that *di* is the non-adjectival counterpart of a concord marker. Building on the functional and semantic similarity of ENs and prenominal adjectives, and on the intuition that *di* belongs to the preceding EN, we propose a parallel between *di* and the concord marker displayed by adjectives. In Italian, as well as in many other languages showing concord, when a RN is modified by an adjective, the latter displays a marker that encodes the same GENDER and NUMBER values as the RN. In Italian resultatives of the type in (36), speakers have the possibility of choosing between using an adjective and thus spelling out the related concord markers, as in (36a), or using a noun, in which case the *di* element surfaces, as shown in (36b). Thus, concord markers and *di* seem to be in complementary distribution, suggesting that they are functionally equivalent.

- (36) a. La sedia la dipingo rossa.
 the chair.F it.F paint.1SG red.F
 b. La sedia la dipingo di rosso.
 the chair.F it.F paint.1SG of red.M

¹¹Relatedly, we exclude that this preposition has a case assignment function (Chomsky 1981, 1986), as witnessed by the German *von*-*DAT fact mentioned above. We also rule out that *di* lexicalizes a functional head that encodes either the pragmatic function ascribed to it by Aarts (1998), or Den Dikken’s (2006) copula-like function, or Kayne’s (1994) determiner-like function. See Rugna and Franco (2022) for an analysis that takes *di* (occurring in compound-like structures) to lexicalize an intersection relator ($\cap$), “which we characterize as intersecting (relevant) properties of the two elements [it relates] in a single zonal domain.”

‘I paint the chair red.’

As we claimed above, semantically, the ENs in QBNPs are similar to adjectives, in that they predicate something over the RN, or, in the case of C-ENs, intensify some other predication. However, morphosyntactically, ENs do not look like adjectives, but rather like semi-lexical nouns or semi-functional adverbial elements.¹² For example, they typically do not agree like adjectives. Such agreement markers on adjectives are uninterpreted (Larson 2022); instead, they merely mark the relation between an individual and a state held by that individual (Higginbotham 1985). Because of their semantic emptiness, and their function of marking a relation between a RN and a modifier, concord markers are reminiscent of other items that have been argued to mark the head-dependent relation, i.e. linkers such as subordinating complementizers (*that*), relative clause markers (Czech *co*), *ezafe*, Mandarin Chinese *de*, etc. (Philip 2013, Larson 2022).

Building on Chomsky (2020), Manzini (2021) claims that link(er)s “have nothing to do with adjectives per se, but rather are devices that enable adnominal modification.” The same can be claimed about concord markers, i.e. we propose a unified analysis of linkers and markers of concord. In other words, we argue that linkers and concord markers can be conceived of as items that serve the same function of marking the relation between a modifier and the RN it modifies (see Tsiakmakis and Espinal 2022 for a similar proposal).

A similar hypothesis can be found in Larson (2022), who discusses Upper Sorbian nouns featuring a marker that attaches to nouns and turns them into “possessive adjectives”.¹³ Crucially, these possessive adjectives retain the ref-

¹²For the possibility of having adverbs/intensifiers modifying a noun, and featuring a preposition-like element between the noun and the adverbs, see e.g. *Clyde is more of an idiot than Floyd Morzycki* (2012), or the already mentioned case of *he’s not much of a cook*.

¹³See also Saab (2022a: 357), who claims that “the semantic connection between the expressive [NP] and the *of*-DP is equation”. Differently from Saab (2022a), though, we maintain that the preposition preceding the RN does not take the RN as its complement, as shown by the fact that *di*-RN cannot be fronted, which is possible for regular PPs, see e.g. **di Cantachiaro ho chiamato quello stronzo (non di McGarrigle)* ‘I have called that asshole of Chiantachiaro (not of McGarrigle)’ vs *Della sedia ho rotto le gambe (non del tavolo)* ‘Of the chair, I broke the leg (not of the table)’. Note that, as suggested by an anonymous reviewer, it seems to be possible to front *di*-RN in echo questions, but only if the EN belongs to the M-/S-EN classes, which highlights the asymmetry between C- and M-/S-EN classes. Addressing echo questions would take us too far afield, so we do not discuss this

erential status, hence they look at the same time like adjectives and nouns. Interestingly, Larson (2022: 86) claims that this “‘genitive’ or ‘adjectivalizing’ morphology can instantiate concordializers” on nouns.¹⁴ Likewise, we maintain that the *di* in QBNPs is to the EN what an agreement marker is to an adjective, i.e. are “devices that enable adnominal modification” (Manzini 2021: 3), surfacing when concord markers cannot. These agreement markers are realizations of agreement heads that are sprouted in the morphological component, and lexicalized postsyntactically (see Sect. 3.4 below for a more detailed development of this idea).

3.2 The make up of C-EN, M-EN, and S-ENs

In this section, we present our proposal concerning the differences in terms of internal syntactic structure of C-ENs, M-ENs, and S-ENs. Together with the two structural positions the ENs can occur in (Sect. 3.3), this explains their different semantic and morphosyntactic behavior, as we shall then show in Sect. 3.4.

3.2.1 The internal structure of C-ENs

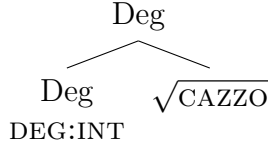
We propose that C-ENs are semi-lexical stage II elements. This means that they contain a root that is combined with a non-categorizing functional head in a separate workspace, after which the complex functions as a head. The functional head the root combines with is a Deg-head, which is valued for the feature Int(ensify) (Kennedy and McNally 2005; see also Gutzmann and Turgay 2015 on intensifiers in a Deg-head in the functional sequence of an adjective). We further assume that the semi-lexical stage II *cazzo* is the

further. We do want to report another piece of evidence, though, supporting our claims, which is the fact that, in coordinated structures, *di* does not need to be repeated, e.g. *quegli stronzi di Vespa, Cazzullo e tutti i leoni da tastiera* ‘these assholes of Vespa, Cazzullo, and all the keyboard lions,’ *quegli stronzi di @justdiscomfort @clarissaisa e @francescadellaciana* ‘these assholes of @justdiscomfort @clarissaisa e @francescadellaciana’. These sentences would be grammatical also with *di*, suggesting that the presence of *di* is optional. This suggests that *di* does not have a head status (Wiltschko 2021), and, in fact, its optionality is reminiscent of the optionality of adjectival markers in languages showing partial concord (Rasom 2008, Cavarani 2018, Bonet 2018, Cavarani 2026).

¹⁴See also Rastorgueva et al. (2012), in Larson (2022), who analyze Gilaki *ezafe* as “genitive case” when attaching to nouns, and “attributive marker” when attaching to adjectives.

result of univerbation, which occurs in the process of grammaticalization. We thus assume that C-ENs are monomorphemic, i.e. they do not consist of a root and a suffix *-o* (or *-i* in elements such as *accidenti*). We submit that, diachronically, the suffix and the root must have univerbized, due to its high frequency and its use contexts. The structure of C-ENs is shown in (37).

(37) Structure of C-ENs



Due to C-ENs being in the second stage of semi-lexicity, they still contain a root. However, because they are directly combined with a functional head, their own lexical semantics is to a certain degree suppressed, and the main semantic content is assumed to come from the functional head itself (Cavirani-Pots 2020). This means that the potential negative semantics of C-ENs associated with lexical taboo words gets bleached compared to that of semi-lexical stage I elements. We assume that the Deg-head which labels the root of C-ENs triggers a semantic interpretation of intensification.¹⁵ Given that C-ENs have a bleached lexical semantics, it follows that they have no intrinsic valence either (see Sect. 2.1 above).

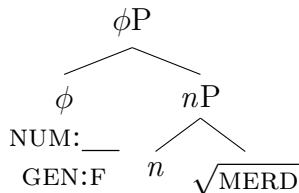
3.2.2 The internal structure of M-ENs

M-ENs are stage I semi-lexical items. That is, they (i) contain a root, (ii) are nominalized by *n*, and (iii) are merged in the functional projection of another, lower, nominalized root. Due to the presence of *n*, M-ENs project their own ϕ -layer. Like lexical nouns, they have inherent gender but no inherent number.¹⁶ The structure of M-ENs is given in (38).

¹⁵See already Meillet (1921: 135ff) on the importance of the concepts of intensity and expressivity in grammaticalization processes. See also Cavirani-Pots (2020), Cavirani-Pots et al. (2026) for formal discussion on which features are retained in the grammaticalization process, and Hopper and Traugott (1993) for cognitive literature on that topic.

¹⁶Despite our bundling of GEN with NUM under ϕ , we do not take any position with respect to whether GEN is a feature of *n* (Lowenstamm 2008, Picallo 2008, Kramer 2015) or an autonomous projection (Picallo 1991, Koopman 2003, De Belder and van Koppen 2016).

(38) Structure of M-ENs

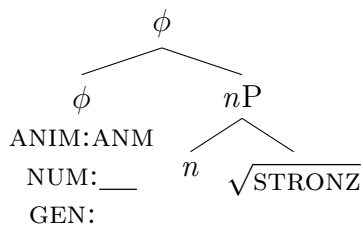


3.2.3 The internal structure of S-ENs

Recall from Sect. 2.1 that the semantics and pragmatics of M-ENs and S-ENs is very similar. We take this to mean that they are at the same level of semi-lexicity—Stage I. That is, we claim that S-ENs—like M-ENs—contain a root, which gets nominalized by n .

However, for S-ENs we need to formalize two more aspects. First, we propose that the ϕ -features on top of the n -head are interpretable, but unvalued Pesetsky and Torrego (2007). We take this to be a defining property of S-ENs and, more generally, of quality nouns (Milner 1978, Ruwet 1982). Second, recall that S-ENs can only co-occur with animate RNs. We take this to mean that there is a valued ANIMACY-feature in their extended projection, which needs to match the ANIMACY of a RN.¹⁷ The structure we propose for S-ENs is represented in (39).

(39) Structure of S-ENs



¹⁷Our analysis is not influenced by the exact position of ANIMACY, which in principle can occur below or above GENDER and NUMBER (Wiltschko and Ritter 2015). We do not take position on the exact implementation of ANIMACY either, and we put ANM in the trees to indicate that, in the animacy hierarchy, the relevant S-EN needs to be at least animate. As argued by (Corbett 2000), if a syntactic process is sensitive to some category on the animacy hierarchy, it will also be sensitive to all higher categories. Thus, S-ENs, which carry the ANIMATE value, can be used with RNs carrying higher values, e.g. HUMAN.

3.3 Two merge positions

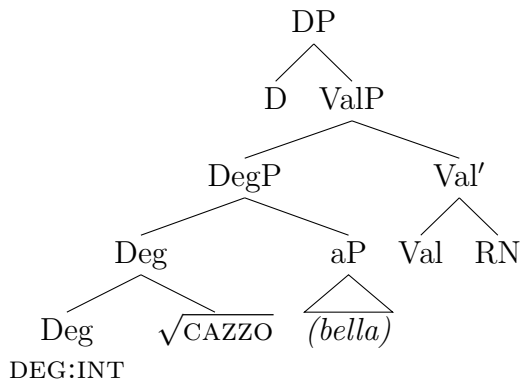
In this section, we present our proposal with regard to the merge positions of ENs in Italian QBNPs. All ENs are merged in the speaker-oriented ValP projection (Cinque 2014, 2015, Rizzi and Cinque 2016). However, the way these ENs appear in the ValP is different for the C-ENs on the one hand, and for M-ENs and S-ENs on the other. The merge position for C-ENs is a head position Deg of a DegP in the extended projection of a (silent) aP, and which is itself in the specifier of ValP. The merge position for M-ENs and S-ENs is directly in the specifier position of this same ValP.¹⁸

3.3.1 The merge position of C-ENs

Morzycki (2009, 2012) and Gutzmann and Turgay (2015) assume that there is a nominal Deg-head in each nominal functional sequence. We refine this and claim that such DegP is in fact in the extended projection of an aP (which can be overt or empty), which sits in the specifier of ValP. As said above, the merge position of C-ENs is this Deg-head. The structural position of C-ENs in QBNPs is illustrated in (40).

¹⁸Scott (1998) and Laenzlinger (2005) propose a richer structure, where the speaker-oriented featural zone include SUBJECTIVE COMMENT, which embeds EVIDENTIAL. The possibility of having these two positions potentially provides for more merge positions for our ENs, and, could allow us to model structures where the C-EN looks similar to a ‘pure expressive’ like *damn.* e.g. in *Leggi quel cazzo di libro!* ‘Read.IMP.2SG that damn book!’ In such an expression, the C-EN conveys the annoyance of the speaker, without expressing anything about the quality of the book (Cuonzo 2024). This could be captured by assuming that C-ENs can also be merged in a Spec-position that does not directly modify a property of the RN. The C-EN could be merged in Spec,EVIDENTIALP, where it modifies an aP or a M/S-EN, or in Spec,SUBJECTIVE COMMENTP, where it modifies some arguably silent head related to the emotional status of the speaker. We leave a full implementation of these ideas for future research.

- (40) Structural position of C-ENs



Recall that we argue that C-ENs are semi-lexical stage II elements. This means that they have the status of a complex head. This allows C-ENs to be merged directly into a head position (unlike M-ENs and S-ENs, as we shall see in the following subsections).

It is clear that the position of this Deg-head should be right above evaluative adjectives—such as *bella* ‘beautiful’ in the example below—because C-ENs can embed such adjectives, but no other functional material modifying the RN:

- (41) Quelle (*cazzo di) nostre (*cazzo di) prime cazzo di belle
 those (dick of) our (dick of) first dick of beautiful
 giornate al mare.
 days at sea
 ‘Those first fucking beautiful days of ours on the beach’

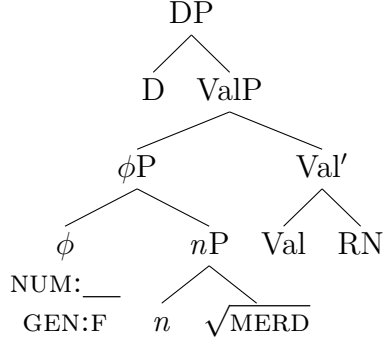
Recall also that C-ENs are valence-neutral, i.e. they intensify properties of a (situation featuring a specific) RN that can have both a positive or negative valence. This now follows from their Merge position: as intensifiers their valence depends on either the valence of the adjective in Spec,Val or—if this adjective is empty—on the context.

3.3.2 The merge position of M-ENs and S-ENs

As we have seen above (see (9b) and (10b)), M-ENs and S-ENs cannot embed evaluative adjectives, unlike C-ENs. We take this to mean that M-ENs and S-ENs occupy the same position as evaluative adjectives, namely Spec,ValP. Since they are semi-lexical Stage I elements, they are not heads but project

their own nominal functional sequence. The structure of QBNPs with M-ENs and S-ENs is illustrated with the M-EN *merda* in (42).

(42) Structural position of M-ENs and S-ENs



3.4 The derivations

With these assumptions in place, we can now go through three sample derivations, one per type of EN, and illustrate how the different concord patterns fall out from the theoretical machinery we set up in the previous sections. In the final section, we return to the prenominal stacking patterns.

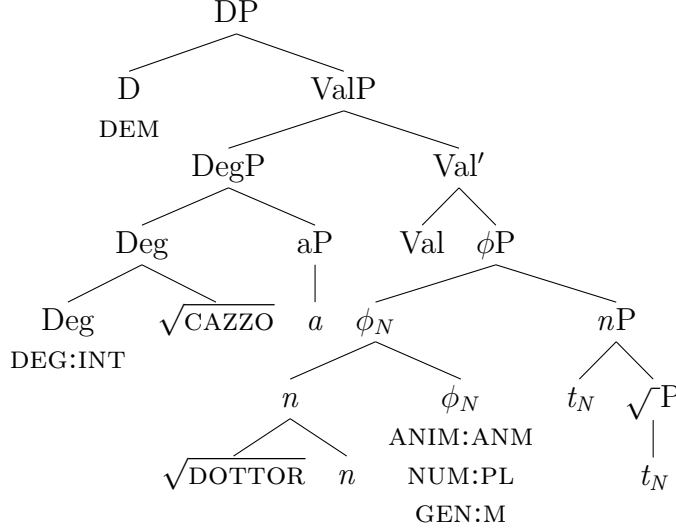
3.4.1 A QBNP with a C-EN

Let us start with the derivation of a QBNP with a C-EN. As an example, we use the QBNP given in (43).

(43) Quei cazzo di dottori.
 those dick of doctors
 ‘Those fucking doctors.’

We first give the syntactic derivation up until the merging of the D-head, which we represent in (44).

(44) Syntactic derivation of C-EN QBNP



Recall that C-ENs are complex heads, consisting of the root *cazzo*, which was combined with a Deg-head valued for an INT-feature in a separate workspace prior to insertion in the main spine. These items are inserted in the Deg-head of DegP, which sits in Spec,ValP. Recall also that we assume that the Deg-head in which C-ENs are merged is in the extended projection of an empty adjective, which means there is no root below the adjectival functional structure in the derivation in (44). In this particular example, the RN is an animate (human) referent, which means that there is a valued ANIM-feature among its phi-features.

Following Bobaljik (2006), Marantz (1991), Choi and Harley (2019) we assume concord to take place postsyntactically via node sprouting (see Sect. 3.1.2). This means that at this point the syntactic derivation of the C-EN QBNP is finished. The postsyntactic operations involve the insertion of ϕ nodes on agreeing elements like determiners, adjectives, and ENs. Recall from Sect. 3.1.2 that we assume *di* to be analogous to adjectival concord, in that it spells out the agreement nodes sprouted in the morphological component. We assume that the agreement node sprouting is triggered by the merger of a (categorized) root in the extended projection of a RN.

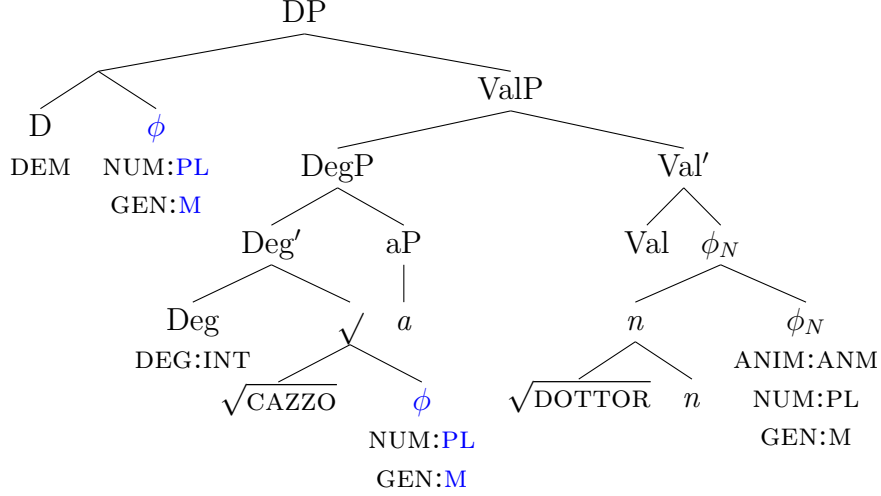
After the ϕ nodes have been sprouted, agreement applies and the value of the relevant features of RN are copied (in a manner that we discuss in more detail below). The resulting structure is now ready to undergo Vocabulary

Insertion. Concretely, we propose the following insertion rules. The ϕ nodes are realized by the concord markers when following an adjectivized root or a functional item f such as a demonstrative or an article, and with *di* otherwise. In the first case, the choice of the specific marker is determined by the GENDER and NUMBER value of the RN.

- (45) Vocabulary Insertion
- | | | | |
|---------------------------|---------------|-------|------|
| $\phi \Leftrightarrow -o$ | $/ \{f, aN\}$ | _____ | M.SG |
| $\phi \Leftrightarrow -a$ | $/ \{f, aN\}$ | _____ | F.SG |
| $\phi \Leftrightarrow -i$ | $/ \{f, aN\}$ | _____ | M.PL |
| $\phi \Leftrightarrow -e$ | $/ \{f, aN\}$ | _____ | F.PL |
| $\phi \Leftrightarrow di$ | (elsewhere) | | |

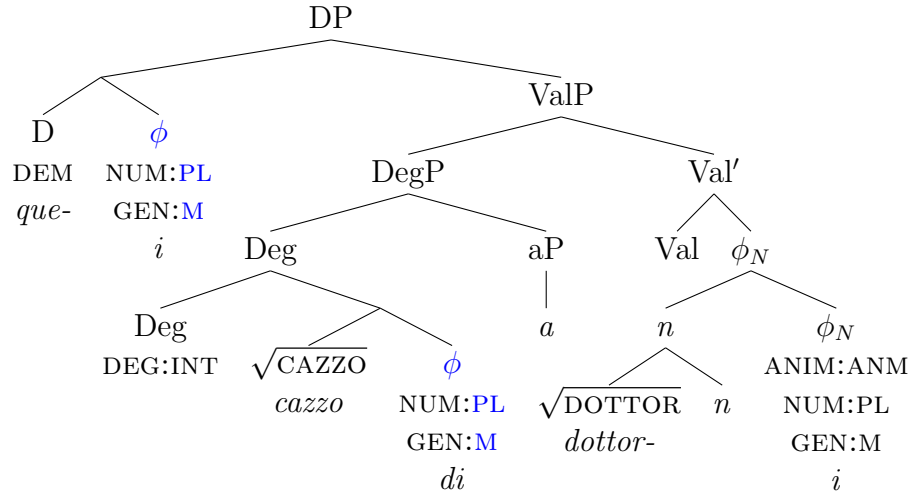
With these rules in place, we now illustrate all postsyntactic operations in (46): (i) the ϕ concord node sprouting on D, (ii) the adjectival ϕ concord node sprouting on $\sqrt{\text{CAZZO}}$, and (iii) agreement between the features on the sprouted ϕ -head of D and $\sqrt{\text{CAZZO}}$ with those of the lower referential noun. We mark in blue these postsyntactic operations of node sprouting and agreement. Since we are now in the morphological component, we also remove the traces of syntactic movement and the phrases they project. After node sprouting, agreement takes place. For concreteness, we describe a top-down application of this agreement process, but a bottom-up application would also work, as far as we can tell. First, the NUM and GEN features on the sprouted ϕ node of D agree with those on the RN (the EN not having any valued features to agree with at this stage). Next, the sprouted ϕ features on the EN also agree with the NUM and GEN features on the RN.

(46) Postsyntactic operations of C-EN QBNP



After node sprouting and agreement, the structure is ready to undergo Vocabulary Insertion. The result after Vocabulary Insertion is given in (47).

(47) C-EN QBNP after Vocabulary insertion

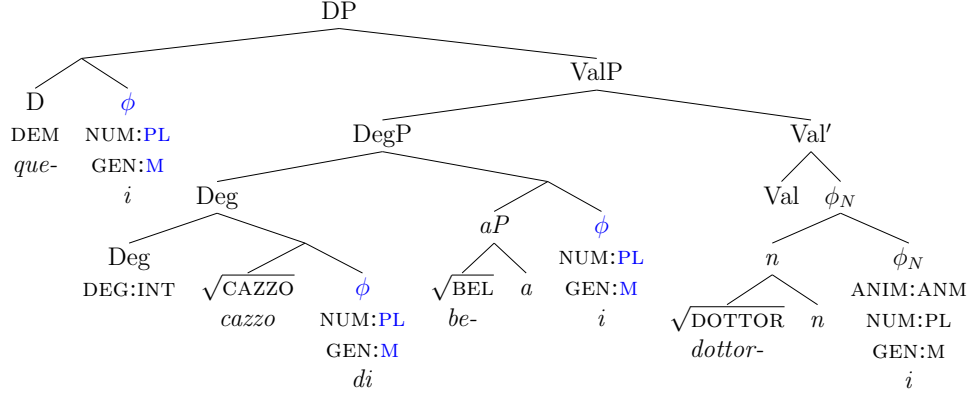


We thus arrive at the QBNP *quei cazzo di dottori*. Under the analysis proposed, the concord patterns of C-EN discussed in Sect. 2.2.3 follow from the fact that agreement between *cazzo* and the RN is present but invisible due to the fact that its ϕ node is realized as *di*.

Recall from Sect. 3.2.1 that C-ENs can embed a Value adjective like *bell-*

‘beautiful’, e.g. *quei cazzo di bei dottori* ‘those fucking beautiful doctors’. The derivation of this structure is like in (48).

(48) C-EN QBNP after Vocabulary insertion (with adjective)



The adjective is also subject to postsyntactic ϕ node sprouting and agreement with the RN, resulting in the attested form *quei cazzo di bei dottori*.

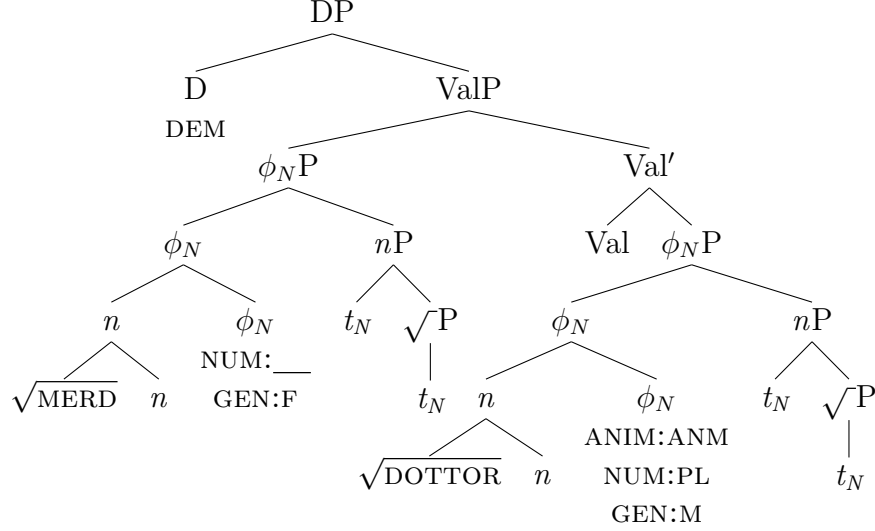
3.4.2 A QBNP with a M-EN

We next look at the derivation of a QBNP with an M-EN, such as the one in (49):

(49) Quelle merde di dottori.
 those shits of doctors
 ‘Those shitheads of doctors.’

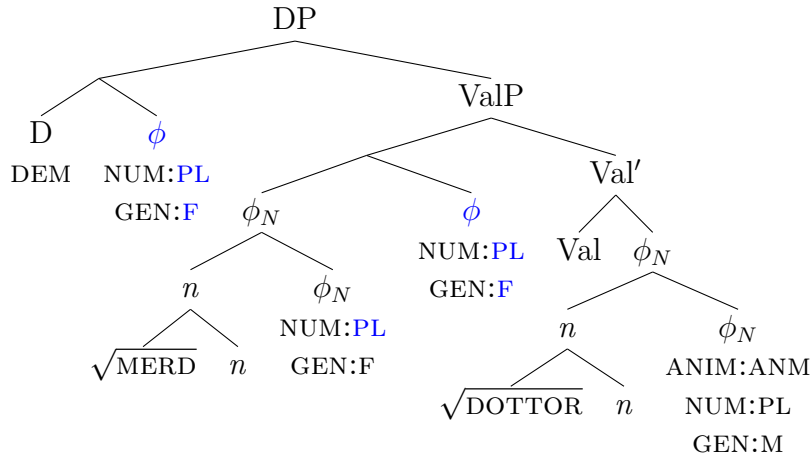
Recall from Sect. 3.2 that we take M-ENs to be semi-lexical elements, i.e. elements containing a root, which gets nominalized, and projects its own ϕ -layer. Furthermore, recall that the GENDER-feature has an intrinsic value (F), whereas the NUM-feature is unvalued. This structure is inserted in Spec,ValP in the extended projection of the RN. After that, the extended projection of the RN keeps on growing, up until the merger and projection of the D-head. The structure we arrive at is given in (50).

(50) Syntactic derivation of M-EN QBNP



With this structure in place, we can now move on to the postsyntactic part of the derivation. As discussed in the previous subsection, we assume concord to take place postsyntactically via node sprouting. The postsyntactic operations involve the insertion of ϕ nodes on D and the M-EN, and agreement. The result of these node sprouting and agreement operations is depicted in (51).

(51) Postsyntactic derivations of M-EN QBNP

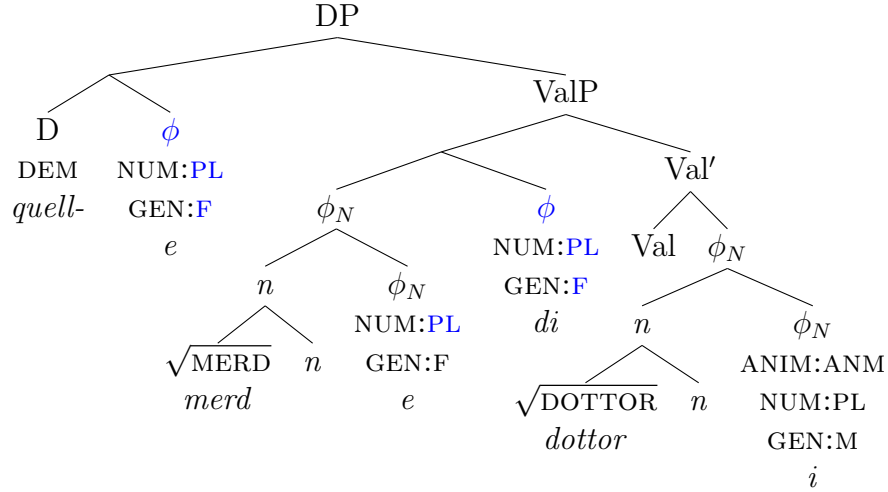


In the first step of the agreement mechanism, the sprouted ϕ node on D looks for a value for its GEN feature, and finds F on the closest ϕ_N node, the one

of the EN. Next, its NUM feature agrees, but since there is no valued NUM on the EN, it looks further down and agrees with NUM:PL of the ϕ_N node of the RN. The second step is the agreement of the sprouted ϕ node on the EN (marked in blue). It finds GEN:F on the EN, and NUM:PL on the RN. Finally, the NUM feature on the ϕ_N node of the EN agrees with the closest NUM:PL feature, which is the one just above it, i.e. the one of the sprouted ϕ node of the EN.

After Vocabulary insertion, we arrive at the QBNP *quelle merde di dottori*, illustrated in (52).

(52) M-EN QBNP after Vocabulary Insertion



Under the analysis proposed, the concord patterns of M-EN discussed in Sect. 2.2.3 follow from the fact that *merda* has a valued GEN-feature but an unvalued NUM-feature in the syntax, which leads to postsyntactic agreement for gender with the EN, and for number with the RN.

3.4.3 A QBNP with a S-EN

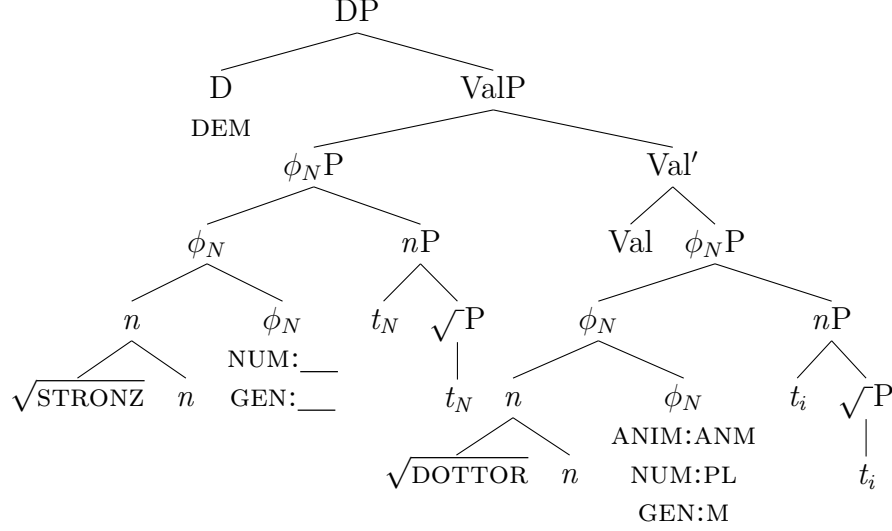
We now turn to a derivation of a QBNP with a S-EN, as the one in (53).

(53) Quegli stronzi di dottori.
 those turds of doctors
 ‘those assholes of doctors’

Recall from Sect. 3.2 that we analyze S-ENs as semi-lexical stage I nouns. Recall also that because of their status as quality nouns, we maintain that

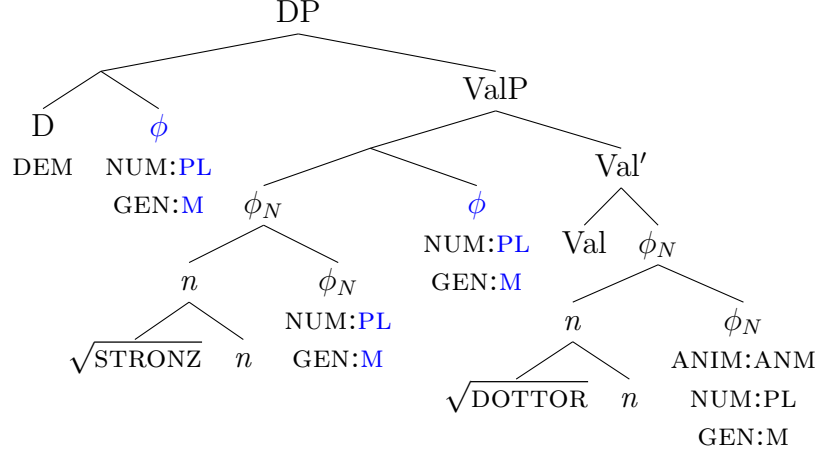
their GEN- and NUM-features are unvalued. Similarly to M-ENs, we argue that S-ENs are merged in Spec,ValP, as shown in (54).

(54) Syntactic derivation of S-EN QBNP



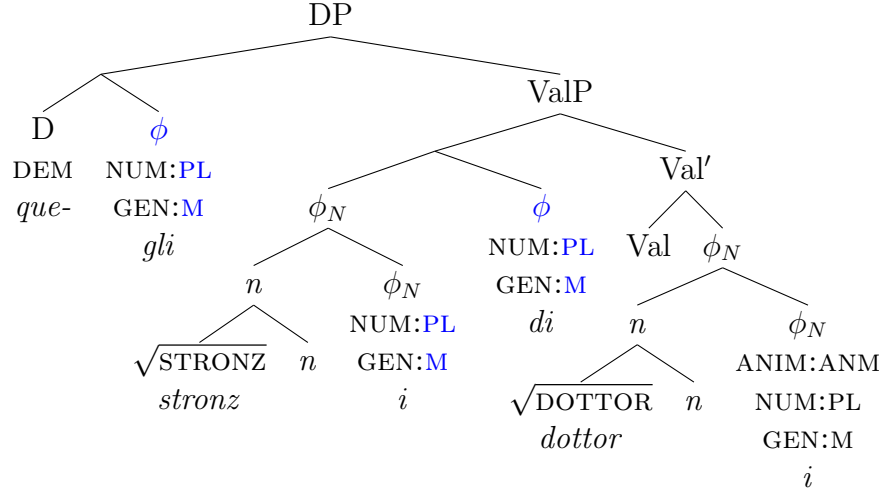
The syntactic derivation is now finished, and we move to the postsyntactic operations. As discussed in the derivations of C- and M-EN QBNPs above, we assume that node sprouting and agreement take place at this point: a ϕ -node is sprouted on D and on the EN. All unvalued ϕ -features — i.e. the ones that are sprouted and the ones of the S-EN — get their value from agreement with NUM:PL and GEN:M of the RN. The result is shown in (55).

(55) Postsyntactic derivations of S-EN QBNP



Now Vocabulary Insertion takes place, as illustrated in (56). The result is *quegli stronzi di dottori*.

(56) S-EN QBNP after Vocabulary Insertion



Under the analysis proposed, the concord patterns of S-EN discussed in Sect. 2.2.3 follow from the fact that *stronzo* has an unvalued GEN-feature and NUM-feature in the syntax, which leads to postsyntactic agreement for both features with the RN. This agreement affects both the node sprouted ϕ -features on D, the unvalued features on the EN, and the sprouted ϕ on the EN.

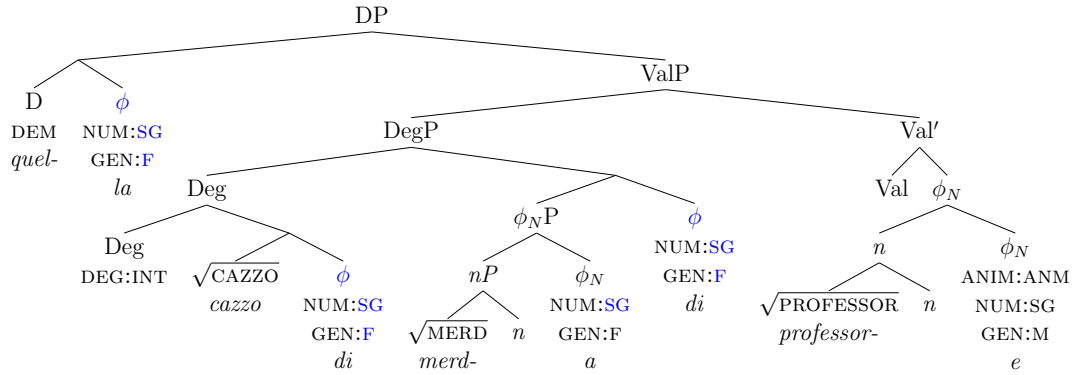
3.4.4 Deriving the stacking pattern

Finally, we want to discuss a case of EN stacking, considering the following example:

- (57) Quella cazzo di merda di professore
 that dick of shit of professor
 ‘that fucking shithead of a professor’

The idea is that the C-EN lexicalizes a DegP inside the extended projection of the M-EN (developing ideas by Morzycki 2009, 2012, Gutzmann and Turgay 2015 on the presence of a Deg-head in the nominal fseq). This DegP then sits in the spec,ValP in the extended projection of the RN. This structure is shown in (58).

- (58) Stacking of C-EN on top of M-EN



The tree also shows the result of postsyntactic operations like agreement node sprouting, agreement, and Vocabulary Insertion. Agreement again works top-down, starting with the demonstrative, which agrees with GEN:F of the M-EN and NUM:SG of the RN. The C-EN does the same, and its ϕ node is lexicalized by *di*. The M-EN agrees with NUM:SG of the RN, as does its sprouted ϕ node, which is lexicalized as *di*, resulting in the QBNP *quella cazzo di merda di professore*.

Stacking structures with M-/S-ENs higher than C-EN is excluded, as it would require for the C-EN to have an extended projection line, which the M-EN could then be a part of. But the C-EN is just a complex Deg head, which does not project its own ϕ -sequence, as we have argued in Sect. 3.2.1 above. Hence the only possible order is for the C-EN to precede the M-EN.

4 Conclusion and outlook

In this paper, we have argued for a tripartite typology of expressive nouns (ENs) which can occur in Italian evaluative binominal structures (QBNPs), where ENs signal the emotional judgment of the speaker on the (situation featuring the) referential noun (RN).

We have shown that these three types of EN show distinct semantic, pragmatic and morphosyntactic properties. In our analysis, we have argued for a difference in degree of grammaticalization of the Italian ENs. C-ENs are semi-lexical stage II elements, i.e. roots that are directly merged with a functional head Deg, whereas M-ENs and S-ENs are semi-lexical stage I elements, i.e. roots that are nominalized by *n*. Thus, M-ENs and S-ENs are phrasal objects that project their own ϕ -layer. The core difference between M-ENs and S-ENs is that M-ENs come with a valued GEN-feature and an unvalued NUM-feature, whereas S-ENs have both features unvalued, in addition to having a valued animacy feature.

With respect to the merge position, we argued that C-ENs are merged in the Deg-head of an empty adjective sitting in the Spec,ValP position of the extended projection of the RN, while M-ENs and S-ENs sit in the Spec,ValP position itself. Using sample derivations of QBNPs with the three types of ENs, we showed that our theoretical assumptions allow us to derive both the observed concord and stacking patterns, while ruling out the impossible ones. We have also shown that our analysis allows us to model the structural and functional parallel shown by concord markers and the preposition-like item *di*.

Several routes for future research present themselves. First, the claim that C-ENs are grammaticalized to a further extent compared to M-ENs and S-ENs can be investigated with a psycholinguistic experiment to see whether C- vs M-ENs and S-ENs are processed differently (see e.g. Domaneschi et al. 2025). Second, we need to provide a detailed description and formal analysis of Italian QBNPs conveying a comparative reading. As discussed in Sect. 2.1.5, these QBNPs differ from the attributive QBNPs analyzed in this paper, both on semantic and syntactic grounds. Third, an analysis needs to be provided of binominal structures featuring C-ENs that are arguably ‘pure expressives’, which encode the attitude of the speaker without saying anything about the RN. In this sense, these structures are slightly different from the QBNOs discussed in this paper, whose ENs convey both the speaker’s perspective and some property of the RN. One crucial question in this respect is

whether ‘pure’ C-ENs have a different internal structure from ‘mixed’ C-ENs, or whether they have the same structure, but they are merged in a different position (see fn 18). Once such questions will be addressed, we will be able to offer a full picture of Italian QBNPs, which shall shed some more light on the theoretical modeling QBNPs in general.

Acknowledgments

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